

Insight from Inside Prison: a Close Reading of Prison Poetry

By Katie McGreer
Submitted to Professor Jackson
For Law 401D
26 April 2010

Insight from Inside Prison: a Close Reading of Prison Poetry

Introduction

In Canada, imprisonment is used as a means of punishing criminals for their wrongdoings. Imprisonment represents strict adherence to the rule of law: culpability begets punishment. But the reasons for detention are not merely punitive. There is a corrective element to our prison system promulgated in section 3(b) of the *Corrections and Conditional Release Act* which stipulates that “the purpose of the federal correctional system is to contribute to the maintenance of a just, peaceful and safe society by **assisting the rehabilitation of offenders** and their reintegration into the community [...]” This corrective element of imprisonment suggests that Canadian legislators have a robust idea of justice.

For the purposes of this paper, I did a close reading of poetry to gain insight on whether the Canadian prison system actually facilitates the rehabilitation of inmates. The study of poetry gives us a view of the prison system that stretches beyond the four corners of the law. Poetry is testimony off the stand, outside the courtroom, and behind the prison gate. The poems *My Heart* by Steven Gareau, *He took up clay* by John Rives, *Of the Fittest* by an anonymous author in Kent, and *Have You Ever* by Sean Jerome shed light on the mind and heart of the prisoner; they account for reality in a way that is “boned with ideas, nerved and blooded with emotions, [and] all held together by the delicate, tough skin of words.”¹ The poems help shape our understanding of prison life by giving an insiders view of how it *feels* to be incarcerated-- a perspective that rarely

¹ A quote about poetry by Paul Engle. See:
<<http://www.worldofquotes.com/topic/Poetry/2/index.html>>

permeates Canada's political-legal discourse. Unfortunately, the poems reveal an ugly truth: prisoners are emotionally wounded, psychologically perturbed and devoid of hope.

Yet, there is room for optimism. Poetry provides us with a valuable tool for meaningful legal reform: empathic concern. With a greater understanding of how prisons affect inmates, we are better equipped to draft fair, progressive penal policy.

The poems

My Heart

by Steven Gareau

My heart is heavy and so full of pain
Like a silent storm with pelting rain
So lonely are these feelings of sorrow
It's hard to believe there is a tomorrow

I thought one time that I was strong
And no matter what I could carry on
Yet these feelings I now feel inside
Have broken my spirit and crushed my pride

I've tried to be a good hearted man
To all others, lend a helping hand
In times of trouble or despair
For others always I've been there

Yet now I sit alone in depression
Slowly folding into a shell of aggression
Undeciphered emotions crowding me
Blinding all hope and eyes to see

As I spiral down this black hole of dust
Until alas at the bottom I do bust
To never feel the warmth of love again
For my heart is heavy and so full of pain

He took up clay
by John Rives

At the encounter group
he took up clay
to represent himself.

Slate-grey clay
was moulded into a single hollow sphere,
dark and featureless
without. Then,
with a fierce cut,
he divided
it in half – in shrieks –
revealing
all the nothingness inside.

He picked up clay
to represent himself,
the seventeen year old,
the accused,
the murderer.

Of the Fittest
by an anonymous author in Kent GP 1989

I survive
solely by conforming
to the rules
of those I am
imprisoned with.
Rules that are
harshly enforced.
Deviation from the code
is met with
punishment and
no hope of appeal.
A man's voice
cannot be heard
from a numbered
grave.
I accept this state
outwardly.
Inwardly, I rage

against the injustice.
Yet I dare not
speak out,
for there is
no one to listen.
So I wear
a perpetual mask
and concentrate on
surviving
one more day.

Have You Ever
by Sean Jerome

Have you ever felt alone in life
Felt no one cared for you
Or been out with a group of friends
And felt alone then too

Have you ever had a broken heart
You felt couldn't be repaired
Or tried to touch someone with your words
And knew nobody cared

Have you ever needed good advice
But were too afraid to call
Or felt separated from the world
Surrounded by a brick wall

Have you ever wondered about your future
And said you couldn't care less
Or tried to pick up all the pieces
But they made one giant mess

Have you ever felt confused
You couldn't even cry
Have you ever felt so damned depressed
Have you ever wished to die

Analysis

The poems *My Heart* by Steven Gareau, *He took up clay* by John Rives, *Of the Fittest* by an anonymous author in Kent GP, and *Have You Ever* by Sean Jerome describe the impact prison has on the prisoner in a way that legislation or commissioned reports cannot. The common thread, strung throughout all four poems, is despair and defeat. For instance, in *My Heart*, Gareau writes that his “heart is heavy.” His pain consumes him and becomes personally debilitating: “I spiral down this black hole of dust / until alas at the bottom I do bust.” Gareau, it seems, is unable to carry the weight of a heavy heart. In *Of the Fittest*, the poet is more explicit about the toll incarceration takes on his spirit. He describes the way he internalizes distress which then morphs into hostility: “Inwardly, I rage against the injustice.” This is his response to the belief there is “no hope of appeal” within the prison. To survive, he becomes emotionally inhibited; he “accept[s] this state outwardly” and “wears a perpetual mask” meanwhile fighting a battle within.

Similarly, in *My Heart*, Gareau writes that he “sit[s] alone in depression/ slowly folding into a shell of aggression/ Undeciphered emotions crowding me/ Blinding all hope and eyes to see.” This extract shows how loneliness morphs into aggression. Gareau describes the way his depression slowly transforms and folds into a shell. The shell is a vivid image: it conveys a retreat into the self; it pulls Gareau inward and causes him to become reclusive. But a shell also gestures toward the idea of a shield, as armour and as a weapon or projectile. Ironically, and somewhat sadly, turning inward is a form of self-initiated isolation and usually only harms the prisoner. To retreat from others invites dire consequences: an implosion or explosion of pent up angst.

John Rives succeeds in conveying a prisoner’s sense of inner turmoil when he

describes a seventeen year old's self representation in *He took up clay*. Rives' subject takes "slate-grey clay" and moulds it into "a single hollow sphere, / dark and featureless/ without." The colour grey is dreary and sets an ominous tone which reflects the mood of the poem. Similarly, clay, by its very nature, is dark and damp. This helps to convey a sense of desperation. The tools used by the subject reflect his anguish just as much as the object he forms out of the clay, which is also hollow, dark, and featureless. This creates a sense of hopelessness.

My Heart also reveals a sense of internal distress. The speaker compares his heart to "a silent storm with pelting rain." The image of a storm casts a dark shadow over the mood of the poem. Since Gareau is comparing the pain he feels to a storm, the rain reminds the reader of tears. The poet's feeling of loneliness is tangible. The poet's choice to compare his heart to a silent storm suggests the poet suffers quietly. Silence here is not tranquil-- it is tumultuous and sorrowful; the poet feels alone: "so lonely are these feelings of sorrow." In the two stanzas that follow, Gareau writes about strength and hope in the past tense – "I was strong" – which suggests that he believes they were something that used to, but no longer, exist: "Yet these feelings I now feel inside / Have broken my spirit and crushed my pride." His despair has dampened his spirit and robbed him of hope.

Sean Jerome shares a sense of helplessness but casts it in a different tone. By using first person narrative, Jerome engages the reader in a more conversational way. But the subject matter is equally haunting; the poet asks his audience whether they have "ever felt separated from the world / Surrounded by a brick wall" and whether they have "tried to pick up all the pieces/ But then made one giant mess." The poet feels separated

from the world but surrounded by the prison; he tries to reconstruct reality but makes a mess of the situation. The reader witnesses his defeat and is left bereft of hope and, like the poet, overcome by a sense of helplessness.

Similarly, Rives conveys a sense of frailty in *He took up clay* when he describes the hollowness of his subject: “with a fierce cut, /he divided/ it in half – in shrieks --/ revealing/ all the nothingness inside.” The extract shows the vulnerability of the human spirit; the young prisoner in the poem has no feeling of self worth. He suffers from the ultimate sign of resignation. Even in *Of the Fittest*, where the poet seems to express a will to survive, his perseverance ends at the end of each day- his endurance follows no trajectory: “concentrate on/ surviving/ one more day.” This is an impoverished notion of survival. It is not a question of thriving; rather, it is about enduring pain and suffering. In fact, the poem opens with the idea that to survive is to conform: “I survive / solely by conforming/ to the rules / of those I am / imprisoned with.” And thus, the poet suggests that to cope and to survive prisoners must surrender something else: their individuality and their autonomy. The idea that death of the individual looms within the prison walls is conveyed when the poet states that “a man’s voice / cannot be heard / from a numbered / grave.” Prisoners’ voices are muted in prison and completely lost at the grave.

The importance of these poems

The selected poetry shows the extent to which prisoners internalize their pain and resign themselves to a sense of hopelessness. Loneliness holds them hostage and tortures their hearts, minds, and souls. Indeed, inmates fall prey to both physical and emotional isolation: it mars them, batters them and eventually defeats them. The poems show the

toll suffering takes on a persons' resilience. While prisoners are able to endure their imprisonment, it crushes their souls in the meantime. This is a reality which escapes the current dialogue regarding corrections: the impact imprisonment has on the human spirit. The effect imprisonment has on inmates' self-worth is especially disconcerting. If prisoners hold themselves in low esteem, give up on their chances of happiness, and channel their pain through hostile and aggressive mediums, rehabilitation is stymied.

Conclusion

Truth is more than facts or legal dicta; some things exists beyond the paradigm under which Corrections now operates. Prison poetry is an instrument of rendering. Truth is revealed by intellectual abstractions and leads us toward a broader understanding of life in prison. Poets beckon us to consider or re-evaluate our notions of justice by reminding us that they are suffering under the harsh realities of prison life.

As such, poetry compels a humanist response to drudgery. By reading inmates' poems, we come to understand that prison not only deprives people of liberty, it also deprives them of hope. The condition of the prisoner, casts a negative impression on the prison system in general and the poems indicate that prisons actually frustrate recovery. If the prison environment is stifling and depressing then how will it be a successful venue for rehabilitation? Since loneliness and hopelessness are the greatest breakers of the human spirit, the biggest challenge for Canadian corrections will be to create a prison environment that is both safe and supportive and, in a sense, liberating. And so, we should use prison poetry as a springboard for activism. Because at the end of the day, the measure of our convictions is our actions.

Works Cited

- Anonymous, "Of the Fittest", *Sentences and paroles: a prison reader*. Ed. P.J. Murphy and Jennifer Murphy. Vancouver: New Star Books, 1998.
- Gareau, Steven. "My Heart", *Cell Count # 50*. Prisoners' HIV/AIDS Support Action Network: Summer, 2008.
- Jerome, Sean. "Have You Ever", *Cell Count #55*. Prisoners' HIV/AIDS Support Action Network: Fall, 2009.
- Rives, John. "He took up clay", *Dead time: poems from prison*. Ed. James Strecker. Hamilton, ont. :Mini Mocho Press, 1989.